



KAUR COMPETENCY

Rashmeet Kaur's new collaboration-filled album *KAURA* showcases her skills as both a singer and a rapper

Rashmeet Kaur calls her new album *KAURA (Aura of Kaur)* a "hip-pop" effort. The singer feels the portmanteau is the perfect way to describe the 12-track collection, which features collaborations with over a dozen hip-hop acts and has her alternating between singing her signature folk-flavoured pop hooks and rapping a few bars. "Folk and pop is my zone, but I've also been listening to a lot of hip-hop in the last few years. Artists like FKJ and Masego who infuse hip-hop into their sound are my vibe," says Kaur, who's equally popular as a playback singer and an independent artist.

Each of the tunes on *KAURA* was made with different combinations of rappers and electronic music producers. The list of credits includes acts with whom she's collaborated before—her former Kalamkaar label mate Ikka, comedian-turned-rapper Munawar Faruqui, beatmakers Gurbax and Rusha & Blizza—as well as artists she wanted to work with—female MCs such as Reble, Simran Kaur Dhadli and Tracy De Sa. "The whole point was to build the community together," says Kaur. "I want to let people know about other people's talent so that it opens a portal for them as well."

KAURA is another example of Kaur's try-everything attitude. The musician has never shied away from putting herself out there and has been part of reality shows such as *The Remix*, which she won with producer Su Real in 2018, and *Fear Factor: Khatron Ke Khiladi*, on which she finished fourth last year. "All my idols are very big believers in experimentation," she says. "Take Beyoncé. She just dropped a country song."

For most artists who traverse both the Bollywood and pop music industries, there's always the risk of their film soundtrack contributions overshadowing their non-film work. *KAURA*, for instance, was released shortly after 'Ishq Nachaawe', Kaur's song from *Kho Gaye Hum Kahan*, took off. But she doesn't see this as a disadvantage. "It's good that 'Ishq Nachaawe' was released, so now my old catalogue and album will also get a push," she says. "People listen to it and then check my artist profile on streaming services and see *KAURA*."

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As for why she chose to release an album in an era of singles, she feels "12 songs mean 12 times the probability of reaching people and getting more hits", adding that while "numbers and reels will come, you can never predict when a track will take off these days". Kaur just put out a music video for the Muhfaad-assisted 'Bholay' to mark Mahashivratri on March 8, the same date as her birthday. "I'm like, why not? The timing is good." ■

–Amit Gurbaxani

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